the sun. Narendra was more pragmatic and from our days in Lucky Seven, I knew I could count on him.

'Sir,' he said, 'we should let him off. There is nothing much against him. Anyone can come and bury anything in someone's fields. It isn't as if we have found the items inside his house.'

'What will we gain from it?' countered Ajay, the Company Commander.

'A lot of goodwill. If we book Razzaq, what will happen to his wife and kids? They will become even more vulnerable to the terrorists. You've seen what the daughters look like. Do you think anyone will leave them alone?'

'Even I tend to agree with that,' I offered. 'While Mustafa was alive, nobody would have dared to touch them. But now, let alone the terrorists, even the police and other sundry agencies will get after them.'

Ultimately, we decided to let him off. Razzaq and family could hardly believe their ears. Razzaq kissed me on the forehead—a mark of great respect. Roja stroked Parmar's chin—a mark of respect and forgiveness. The daughters appointed us their honorary *mamas* or uncles. The mood was altogether different from what it had been when they had come initially. We were friends now. As they left the post, we definitely felt we had done our duty. Our duty to that final arbitrator above.

We continued to meet off and on. On the occasion of Eid, Razzaq came to the camp on his own with some chicken specially made for us by his daughters. On another visit, with some walnuts and other fruits from his farm. We too reciprocated. When he visited the next time, I sent a return gift of some perfumes, lipsticks and other cosmetics for Javeeda and Chaspeeda—they were my nieces, after all!

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